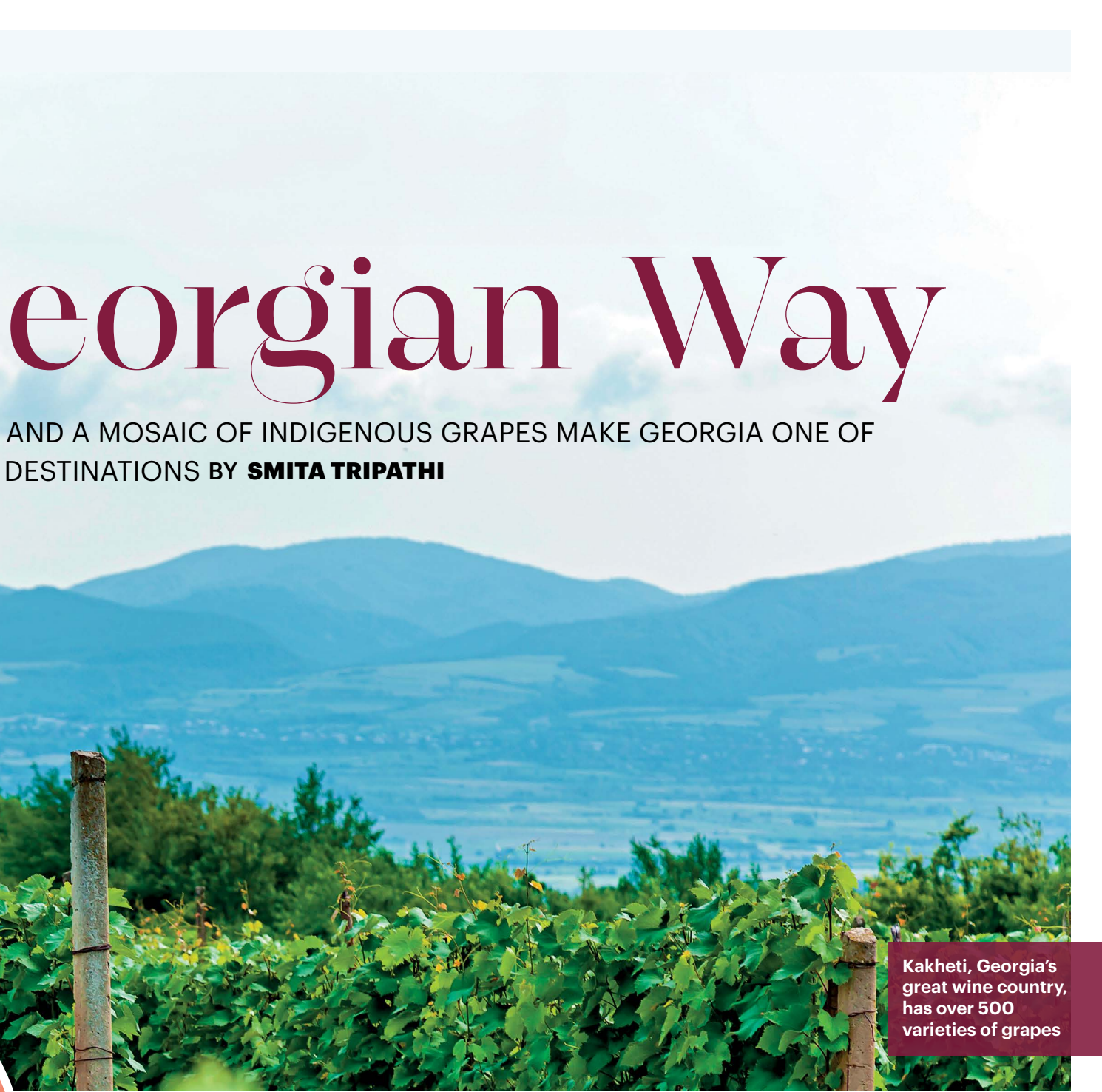


Georgian Way

AND A MOSAIC OF INDIGENOUS GRAPES MAKE GEORGIA ONE OF
DESTINATIONS BY **SMITA TRIPATHI**



Kakheti, Georgia's
great wine country,
has over 500
varieties of grapes

8,000 years! What's remarkable is how it still survives.

Wine is not simply something poured into a glass in Georgia. It appears in religion, hospitality, landscape, and even the national iconography. Look up at Kartlis Deda—the 20-metre Mother of Georgia who watches over Tbilisi—and she holds a bowl of wine in one hand for friends and a sword in the other for enemies. Step into an Orthodox church and you hear the story of Saint Nino, the fourth-century missionary credited with bringing Christianity to Georgia, whose distinctive drooping cross was fashioned from grapevine

shoots and bound, according to tradition, with strands of her own hair.

Walk through Tbilisi and you find wine everywhere—from tasting rooms and tiny family-run wine estates and cellars to vines climbing across courtyards. But to really understand